8-WEEK PLAN

The Conjugate Method

8 weeks, 6 days.

Days 6 a week **Session** 50–55 min **Equipment** Full commercial gym

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What this is

Muscle grows from two different signals. The first is heavy tension: a set under a load that only allows a handful of reps, taken to the point where the next rep will not move. The second is metabolic stress: the pump, a muscle kept full of blood under short rest until it burns. Most programs make you choose one. This plan runs both in the same session, on the same muscle. One anchor set to real failure, two bridge sets at two reps in reserve, then a seven-set finisher with the clock running. The anchor set comes from the heavy-duty tradition and the seven-set finisher from the pump tradition of pro bodybuilding. Running both in one session, with a bridge between them, is the part that's mine. The split is push, pull, legs, twice through, six days. Each day one priority muscle gets the full treatment, one secondary muscle gets an anchor set and bridge work, and the small muscles close the session as a superset, two movements back to back. One finisher a day, never two. That rule is what keeps a session near 50 minutes. The eight weeks are two four-week blocks: three weeks climbing a rep ladder at one load, one lighter week, then the same again heavier. Week 8 ends with a re-test against week 1, so you leave with a number, not a feeling.

Who it's for

- Advanced lifters, two or more years of consistent training.
- Six days a week available, 50 to 55 minutes a session.
- A full commercial gym.
- Sleep, food and stress already in order. This plan spends recovery, it does not create it.

Who it's not for

- Anyone under a year of training. Run Upper / Lower or Push / Pull / Legs first.
- Anyone who cannot train six days. The volume does not compress into four. Run the four-day version of this plan instead.
- Anyone in a hard cut. Failure work on a large deficit is how you get hurt and lose muscle at the same time. Run the four-day version at Level 1.

Equipment: a full commercial gym. Barbells, a Smith machine, dumbbells, adjustable benches, a machine shoulder press, a cable station with a rope and single handles, a hack squat and a leg press, leg extension, seated leg curl, a 45-degree hip extension bench, chest-supported row, pulldown, preacher bench, reverse pec deck and a hip thrust setup.

Before you start

Five rules.

1. The plan is decided before the week starts. You do not pick exercises in the gym. You open the table and do what it says.
2. Weekly averages, never single weigh-ins. Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water and food. One number is noise. Use the seven-day average.
3. A missed day is data, not failure. It tells you what in the plan doesn't fit your life yet.
4. Log every session. The plan works off the record. Load, reps, and how many reps you had left, every set.
5. Progress is checked against the record, not how you feel. A session that felt bad and beat last week's numbers was a good session.

Finding your starting loads

There are no fixed weights anywhere in this document. Week 1, session 1 of each day is a load-finding session. The rule for each set type:

- Anchor set: climb through the ramp sets to a load where the bottom of the written range is the last clean rep. If you get two or more reps past the bottom of the range before failing in week 1, go up next session.
- Bridge sets: a load you can lift for the bottom of the range with two reps left. The bridge is always a different movement from the anchor, so it gets its own load.
- Finisher: a load you can do for 12 clean reps on set 1 with two left. It will feel light. By set 5 it will not.
- Superset sets: the bottom of the range with two left. Light and strict.

Write every starting load down in session 1. Weeks 2 and 3 are built on those numbers.

The warm-up

Five minutes, the same every session.

1. Three minutes on a bike or rower at a pace you can talk through.
2. Ten arm circles each way, ten leg swings each side, ten squats, ten band pull-aparts.
3. Before every anchor set, ramp sets. They are not counted and not in the tables. The first anchor of the day gets three: about half the anchor load for 8 reps, about 70 percent for 5, then 85 to 90 percent for 2. Rest 60 seconds after the first, 90 seconds after the second, two minutes before the anchor. The reps drop as the load climbs, so the ramp warms the muscle without tiring it. The last ramp set is the check. If it moves slower than it should, today's anchor load comes down. An anchor later in the session, on a muscle that is already warm, gets two (70 percent for 5, then 85 to 90 percent for 2) or one (80 percent for 3), as its row says. The ramp sets are how you find the anchor load, so do not skip them.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

The eight weeks

WEEK	WHAT CHANGES	LOAD RULE	NOTES
1	Load-finding week. Bottom of every rep ladder.	Find and log every starting load.	Anchor sets to failure from day 1. Log the rest-pause reps.
2	One more rep per set.	Same load as week 1.	6 becomes 7. 4 becomes 5.
3	One more rep per set.	Same load. Top of the ladder.	Note every set that hit the top.
4	Deload.	Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load.	Three to four in reserve. No sets to failure, no finishers.
5	New block. Bottom of the ladder.	Up 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones, wherever week 3 hit the top.	Otherwise same load, ladder again.
6	One more rep per set.	Same load as week 5.	
7	One more rep per set.	Same load. Top of the ladder.	The heaviest week of the plan.
8	Deload and re-test.	Deload rules, plus the re-test below.	The number you walk away with.

The ladder

Weeks 1 to 3 are one block. The load does not change. The reps do. Every set is written as a ladder: 8→9→10 means eight reps in week 1, nine in week 2, ten in week 3, at the same weight. Anchor sets run 4→5→6 or 6→7→8 the same way, each week to failure plus rest-pause. The finisher runs its own ladder at one load across all seven sets.

Week 4 is the deload. Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load, three to four reps in reserve on every set. The anchor set becomes one set at the bridge load, stopped with three or four left. The finisher comes out and is replaced by two easy sets of the same movement. The superset stays, lighter. The deload is not a week off. It is the week the growth from weeks 1 to 3 gets built.

Week 5 starts the second block. Every movement that hit the top of the ladder in week 3 at the written reps in reserve goes up: 5 to 10 lb on presses, rows, squats and deadlifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on curls, raises, extensions and flyes, back to the bottom of the ladder. Any movement that did not reach the top keeps its load and runs the ladder again. Weeks 6 and 7 add a rep each.

Week 8 is the second deload, with one addition. In the last session of each day type, do one set of every anchor movement at week 1's anchor load for week 1's reps, and stop there. You will not fail it. The point is to count what is left. In week 1 that load took you to failure at the bottom of the range. In week 8 it should leave two, three or more in reserve. Log the difference for each movement. No anchor sets to failure in week 8 and no finishers.

Deload triggers

Any one of these fires a deload the same week, then you resume the block where you left it.

- Performance on a key lift drops two sessions in a row.
- Five days of feeling flat and heavy.
- A week of bad sleep.

Load-drop rules

If one muscle is going backwards while the rest of the body is fine, you do not need a full deload. Cut that muscle's sets by 30 to 40 percent for one week, superset sets first. The anchor set and the finisher on its priority day are the last things to touch. If two muscles are dropping at once, that is recovery, not programming. Deload.

The sessions

Every session has the same shape. The priority muscle goes first and gets the full treatment: anchor set, two bridge sets, finisher. The secondary muscle gets an anchor set and two bridge sets, no finisher. On leg days the secondary muscle gets bridge sets only, because its anchor set is three days away. The small muscles close the session as a superset. Tempo is four digits: seconds down, pause at the bottom, seconds up, pause at the top. 3-0-1-0 is three seconds down, no pause, one second up, no pause. On the anchor set the last reps slow down on their own. That is fine. Rest is written per row and it is timed, not felt.

The anchor set. One set to real failure, then rest-pause. Real failure means the next rep would not move with good form, not the point where it gets uncomfortable. Rack the weight. Count fifteen to twenty seconds. Unrack and get two or three more reps. Rack it. That is the set. The anchor movement is always one you can rack in a second: a Smith machine, a machine, or a bar you can set down. Never heavy dumbbells. The rest-pause needs a fast re-rack, and with heavy dumbbells the set ends on getting them into position, not on the muscle. One per muscle per session, never two. Three minutes rest after it, and nothing done in that rest. The anchor set is where the tension signal comes from, and it needs the full three minutes.

The bridge sets. Back-off work at two reps in reserve, strict. The load is one you can lift for the bottom of the range with two left. The bridge adds mechanical work without spending the recovery the anchor set already spent. Never to failure. Two minutes rest on compounds, 90 seconds on isolations.

The finisher. Seven sets of one movement at one load, 30 to 45 seconds rest between sets, timed. Sets one to six stop at one or two reps in reserve. Set seven goes past failure with partial reps or one drop in load. The rest is short enough that the muscle never empties. It stays full of blood the whole time, and that swelling is the second growth signal. Only the priority muscle gets one.

The superset. The small muscles close the session with two movements done back to back. One set of the first, straight into one set of the second, then 60 seconds rest. That is one round. The two movements work opposite muscles, so each one rests while the other works. Each movement loads its muscle in the stretched position, where the growth signal is strongest. Two or three rounds at two reps in reserve. Never to failure. Set both movements up on one cable tower where you can, so a round has no walking. Day 4 has one movement here, done as straight sets. The bridge rests stay empty. The bridge sets carry the tension signal, and they need the full rest to do it.

The clock. Sessions fit 50 to 55 minutes with the rests timed. If a session runs past 60 minutes, check the rests first. Untimed rest is where the minutes go. If it still runs long, drop one round of the superset, then cut the secondary muscle's bridge to one set. The priority muscle's anchor set, bridge sets and finisher are never cut for time.

Day 1: Push A

Focus: chest. Shoulders secondary. Biceps and triceps superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Incline Smith press, anchor set	1	4→5→6	2-0-1-0	3:00	Ramp sets first. Bench at 30 degrees, bar to the upper chest. To failure, then rest-pause: rack 15 to 20 seconds, two or three more reps.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Flat dumbbell press, bridge	2	8→9→10	3-0-1-0	2:00	Two in reserve.
Low-to-high cable fly, finisher	7	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Same load all seven sets. Sets 1 to 6 one or two in reserve. Set 7 past failure with partials.
Seated Smith shoulder press, anchor set	1	4→5→6	2-0-1-0	3:00	Two ramp sets. The shoulders are warm from the press. Bench upright, bar just in front of the face. Failure plus rest-pause.
Cable lateral raise, bridge	2	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	90 s	Lean away from the stack so the cable loads the bottom. Lead with the elbow.
Behind-the-body cable curl, superset	2	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Face away from the stack, arm behind the body. Strict.
Overhead cable extension, superset	2	12→13→14	3-1-1-0	60 s after the round	Same tower. Full stretch behind the head, elbows in.

Substitutions: no Smith machine, use an incline machine press for the chest anchor and a machine shoulder press for the shoulder anchor. When the flat dumbbells get awkward to kick into place, use a machine chest press for the bridge. No low-to-high cable, use a pec deck with the handles set low or an incline dumbbell fly. No cable for laterals, use seated dumbbell lateral raises. No cable for the superset, use an incline dumbbell curl and a two-hand dumbbell overhead extension.

Day 2: Pull A

Focus: back. Biceps secondary. Rear delts and triceps superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Underhand barbell row, anchor set	1	4→5→6	2-0-1-0	3:00	Ramp sets first. Torso slightly upright, pull to the hip. Failure plus rest-pause. This builds the lower lat.
Wide-grip pulldown, bridge	2	8→9→10	3-0-1-0	2:00	Width. Two in reserve.
Overhead cable pullover, finisher	7	12→13→14	2-1-1-1	30–45 s	Big stretch at the top, full lat contraction at the bottom. Set 7 past failure.
EZ-bar curl, anchor set	1	4→5→6	2-0-1-0	3:00	Two ramp sets. Failure plus rest-pause.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Incline dumbbell curl, bridge	2	8→9→10	3-1-1-0	90 s	Arm hangs behind the body. Stretched position.
Prone incline rear delt raise, superset	2	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Chest on an incline bench, arms straight, palms down, chin tucked. Raise out to the sides and stop at the line of the torso. Past that point the shoulder blades squeeze and the traps and rhomboids take the work.
Overhead cable extension, superset	2	12→13→14	3-1-1-0	60 s after the round	Full stretch behind the head, elbows in.

Substitutions: no barbell for the row, use an underhand chest-supported machine row or a single-arm dumbbell row. No pulldown, use pull-ups. No overhead cable for the pullover, use a dumbbell pullover. No EZ-bar, use a straight bar or dumbbells. No incline bench for curls, use a cable curl facing away from the stack. No incline bench for the rear delt raise, use a reverse pec deck with the same stopping point. No cable for the extension, use a two-hand dumbbell overhead extension.

Day 3: Legs A

Focus: quads. Hamstrings secondary, bridge sets only. Abs superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Hack squat, anchor set	1	4→5→6	2-0-1-0	3:00	Ramp sets first. Feet mid-platform. Set the safety stops before the set. Failure plus rest-pause.
Leg press, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-0-1-0	2:00	Two in reserve.
Leg extension, finisher	7	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Seat reclined if the machine allows. Set 7 past failure with partials.
45-degree hip extension, bridge	2	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	2:00	Round the upper back slightly and drive with the glutes and hamstrings, not the lower back. Hold a plate once bodyweight is easy. The heavy hinge is saved for Day 6, and the lower back already worked on Day 2.
Seated leg curl, bridge	2	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	90 s	One or two in reserve.
Cable crunch, superset	3	20	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Pull with the abs, not the arms. Full range.
Hanging leg raise, superset	3	15	2-0-1-0	60 s after the round	No swing. Control the descent.

Substitutions: no hack squat, use a machine squat or a leg press with the feet low. No leg press, use a heavy goblet squat. No leg extension, use a sissy squat and accept a weaker finisher. No hip extension bench, use a cable pull-through. No cable crunch, use a weighted crunch holding a plate. No hanging bar, use lying leg raises.

Day 4: Push B

Focus: side delts. Triceps secondary. Chest volume and rear delts.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Machine shoulder press, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Ramp sets first. Failure plus rest-pause.
Cable lateral raise, bridge	2	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	90 s	Two in reserve. Lean away from the stack. Lead with the elbow.
Dumbbell lateral raise, finisher	7	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Same dumbbells all seven sets. Cut out the very bottom, where a dumbbell puts no load on the delt. Set 7 past failure with partials.
Close-grip machine press, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Two ramp sets. Elbows tucked at about 30 degrees. Failure plus rest-pause.
Overhead cable extension, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-1-1-0	90 s	Full stretch behind the head, elbows in. The long head grows here. Never skip it.
Incline machine press, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-0-1-0	2:00	Chest volume. Two in reserve.
Reverse pec deck, partial range, to close	2	15→16→17	2-0-1-1	60 s	Straight sets. Stop when the arms reach the line of the torso, before the shoulder blades squeeze.

Substitutions: no machine shoulder press, use a high-incline Smith press. No cable for laterals, use seated dumbbell lateral raises. No close-grip machine, use a close-grip barbell bench or a dip machine. No overhead cable, use a two-hand dumbbell overhead extension. No reverse pec deck, use the prone incline rear delt raise from Day 2. No incline machine, use an incline dumbbell press.

Day 5: Pull B

Focus: biceps. Back secondary, and back runs first. A seven-set biceps finisher before the rows would cap the row anchor, so this is the one day the priority muscle goes second. Side and rear delts superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Chest-supported row, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Ramp sets first. Failure plus rest-pause.
Single-arm cable row, bridge	2	12→13→14 each side	2-0-1-1	90 s	Full stretch forward, elbow to the hip. Both sides, then rest.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Preacher curl, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	One ramp set. Failure plus rest-pause.
Incline dumbbell curl, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-1-1-0	90 s	Arm hangs behind the body.
Behind-the-body cable curl, finisher	7	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Face away from the stack, arm behind the body. Constant tension. Set 7 past failure.
Leaning cable lateral raise, superset	2	15→16→17	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Hold the tower, lean away, cable from behind the body. Each side.
Reverse cable fly, superset	2	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	60 s after the round	Same tower. Arms long, pull wide, stop at the line of the torso.

Substitutions: no chest-supported row machine, use a dumbbell row with the chest on an incline bench. No single-arm cable, use a single-arm dumbbell row. No preacher bench, use a spider curl over the high side of an incline bench. No cable for the delt superset, use seated dumbbell lateral raises and bent-over dumbbell rear delt raises. No cable for the finisher, use a standing dumbbell curl, same load all seven sets.

Day 6: Legs B

Focus: hamstrings and glutes. Quads secondary, bridge sets only. Abs superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Romanian deadlift, anchor set	1	4→5→6	3-0-1-0	3:00	Ramp sets first. To failure with good form, no rest-pause on this one. A hinge gets no second attempt when the back is tired.
Hip thrust, bridge	2	8→9→10	2-0-1-1	2:00	Chin down, ribs down, full lockout.
Seated leg curl, finisher	7	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Same load all seven. Set 7 past failure with partials.
Leg press, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-0-1-0	2:00	Two in reserve.
Leg extension, bridge	2	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	90 s	Two in reserve.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Cable crunch, superset	3	20	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Full range. Control the return.
Hanging leg raise, superset	3	15	2-0-1-0	60 s after the round	No swing. Control the descent.

Substitutions: no seated leg curl, use a lying leg curl for the finisher. No hip thrust setup, use a barbell glute bridge on the floor or a glute machine. No leg press, use a hack squat or a heavy goblet squat. No cable crunch, use a weighted crunch holding a plate. No hanging bar, use lying leg raises.

The week

DAY	SESSION	PRIORITY MUSCLE, FULL TREATMENT	SECONDARY MUSCLE	SUPERSET TO CLOSE
Monday	Push A	Chest	Shoulders	Biceps, triceps
Tuesday	Pull A	Back	Biceps	Rear delts, triceps
Wednesday	Legs A	Quads	Hamstrings, bridge only	Abs
Thursday	Push B	Side delts	Triceps, plus chest volume	Rear delts
Friday	Pull B	Biceps, after back	Back	Side and rear delts
Saturday	Legs B	Hamstrings and glutes	Quads, bridge only	Abs
Sunday	Off	None	None	Walk, stretch, mobility. No lifting.

There is no rolling alternative. The six sessions sit on fixed days so every muscle's two hard days are 72 hours apart: shoulders Monday and Thursday, back and biceps Tuesday and Friday, quads Wednesday and Saturday, hamstrings Wednesday and Saturday. A missed day is slotted in on the next free day, never doubled.

Progression and troubleshooting

Adding load. Load changes once per block, at the start of week 5, and only on movements that hit the top of the ladder in week 3 at the written reps in reserve. 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones. Mid-block the load holds and the reps climb. If an anchor set gets two or more reps past the bottom of its range in week 1 before failing, the load was wrong, not the plan. Go up next session and restart that movement's ladder.

A stalled lift. A lift stalls when the reps do not climb at the same load two weeks running. Hold the load. Add reps where you can, even one on one set. If it is still stalled after two weeks, drop the load 10 percent, run the ladder from the bottom, and climb back. You will pass the old number on the way up. Grinding at the old load is how a stall becomes a month.

A missed session. Slot it in on the next free day and push the rest of the week along by one. Never double up. Two missed sessions in the same week means the plan is too big for that week. Run Plan B from the compliance page for the rest of the week and start the next week on schedule. The log tells you where you were.

Poor sleep. A night under six hours caps that day. The anchor set runs at the bridge load with two in reserve, no set to failure. The finisher runs as seven sets at two in reserve, no set 7 past failure. A week of it is a deload trigger.

Failing safely. An anchor set to failure is safe when the setup is right. Safety stops set before the set. A Smith machine with the hooks in reach. Failure on the Romanian deadlift is form failure, the rep where the back wants to round. If you cannot set a movement up safely, take the machine version from the substitutions to failure instead.

When to stop. Muscle fatigue is dull, spread out, and goes away with rest. Pain that is sharp, in a joint, on one side, or that changes how you move is not fatigue. Stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

Cardio and walking

Walk most days, 20 to 40 minutes, at a pace you could hold a conversation at. On this plan that is the cardio. Six lifting days with anchor sets and finishers already spend the recovery budget. Hard conditioning on top comes out of muscle, not fat.

Sunday is walking, stretching and mobility only. Nothing that leaves you sore for Monday.

Hard cardio is optional and this plan does not ask for it. If you want it, one short session on Sunday, easy enough that Monday is unaffected. Never before lifting.

The compliance page

Plan A, the full week

- All six sessions done, on their days.
- All six sessions logged, rest-pause reps included.
- Protein target hit every day, 1 g per lb of bodyweight as the default line.
- Weekly weigh-in average recorded.
- Walks done.

Plan B, the bare minimum

When the week blows up, Plan B is a full week. Three sessions: one push, one pull, one legs. Run Push A, Pull A and Legs A, and in each one do the ramp sets and the anchor set for every anchor movement, then the priority muscle's two bridge sets. No finishers, no supersets. One hard set per muscle keeps the stimulus alive and the session takes 20 to 30 minutes. Protein still hit. Sessions still logged. A Plan B week counts as a week done.

Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom. Log it.
- Photos front, side, back, same light, same place.
- Read the whole of week 1 before day 1. Every table, every note.
- Put the six session days in a calendar now, with the time.
- Pick the Plan B days now, before you need them. One push, one pull, one legs.

Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.

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Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.